

are used for modems and NICs (though they're also used for RAM). Type III cards are much thicker—10.5mm—and often are used for hard disks and radio devices. A PC Card slot on a computer is usually designated by the thickest card it can accommodate. A Type II PC Card slot, for instance, can take a Type I PC Card as well as a Type II (and it might be called a Type I/II), but it cannot fit a Type III.

PCI

Peripheral Component Interconnect. If you have a Pentium system, it's extremely likely that it runs a self-configuring PC local bus called PCI. Designed by Intel, PCI has gained wide acceptance—even by Apple, in its PowerPC series.

PCMCIA

Personal Computer Memory Card International Association. This acronym stands for the name of a trade association founded in 1989 to establish standards for expansion cards for portable computers. Based in Sunnyvale, California, the PCMCIA's specifications for the PC Card enabled the computer industry to manufacture credit-card-size removable cards to add RAM, modems, network adapters, hard disks, and even radio devices such as pagers and global positioning systems to portable computers. Many people call PC Cards by the longer name 'PCMCIA cards'. The association has trademarked the term PC Card, however, which is therefore the preferred usage.

Ping

When submarine crews wanted to determine the distance of an object from themselves, they'd send a sonar ping and wait to hear the echo. In the computer world, 'ping' is a program that 'bounces' a request—in other words, sends a packet—over the Internet to another computer to see if the remote computer is still responding. If the ping returns, the remote computer is still connected. Some people think 'ping' stands for 'Packet Internet Groper', but according to the inventor of Ping, that is a secondary acronym.